

Congress got his chief whip to threaten a split and offered the post of deputy chief minister to the son and Union Coal Ministry to the father. It helped though the Congress also reminded Soren that the appeal against his acquittal in the Jha murder case was open to debate. The combination of carrot-and-stick worked.

What helped was that the targets and interlocutors were intelligently chosen and aligned. If Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel and P.A. Sangma networked successfully to convince the single-MP parties from North-east, Sharad Pawar was used to crack the complex equations. Getting Omar Abdullah to vote on the same side as PDP was no mean task but it was Pawar who worked on him. Of course, it helped that Abdullah used to stay with the Pawars while studying in Mumbai.

Take the case of the Karnataka MPs. It is no secret that the BJP was uncomfortable living under the support of the Bellary miners. Its solution was to beef up its numbers by getting Congress MLAs to resign and contest as BJP candidates, a replica of how the Congress wrecked the Shiv Sena using Narayan Rane. Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Y.S.R. Reddy,

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The emergence of Mayawati could have derailed the Congress campaign. But by suggesting that the rise of UNPA spelt the end of the road for NDA, the UPA spin masters split the ranks of the Opposition to their advantage.

who has known the miners, read this as an opportunity to tap and got the Bellary MLAs to work with him to lure four BJP MPs. Interestingly, barring one, all were former Congressmen and even H.T. Sangliana was lured with a ticket from Mizoram. In their efforts, the party managers have combined arithmetic and politics. The Congress got the numbers and also succeeded in puncturing the euphoria created by the BJP's victory in the Assembly polls.

The campaign was not without hiccups. The weekend before the trust vote, they lost JD(S) and RLD as both Deve Gowda and Ajit Singh found the idea of the third front alluring to dump the promises made to the Congress. Indeed the emergence of Mayawati and the power play by a couple of corporate houses almost derailed the campaign. Two tactical errors—the unveiling of the CBI case on Mayawati by spin masters and the open attack of Amar Singh on corporate interests almost created a new wall of resistance. Thinking on their feet, the Congress sent emissaries to the

corporates. A senior minister close to the tycoon assured immunity from the SP even as he read the riot act, armed as he was with some “interesting” documents. Just in case the tycoon got ideas. Amar too exercised discretion in his tirade on the battle between the Ambani brothers. Once money power was neutralised, they worked on the political angle. Almost on cue, CPI General Secretary A.B. Bardhan anointed Mayawati as the future prime minister. That was the political equivalent of setting the cat among the pigeons. Using the dissident network in the BJP, they spread the word that the emergence of UNPA would threaten the future of the NDA. Suddenly the idea of toppling the UPA Government didn't look all that attractive.

What was amazing is the persistence of the core team. Even though by July 20 evening the UPA was convinced that it had the numbers, it did not stop pursuing its quarry. An emissary went and met Gowda and Ajit Singh just in case they would change their minds. They didn't but oth-